

Venues

Paris 2024: 35 venues, 329 events

Tokyo 2020: 41 venues, 339 events

India: The Rs 4,000 crore, 650-acre Sardar Vallabhbhai Patel sports enclave will be India's Olympic city, with more than 10 stadiums, and 14 other venues besides the Narendra Modi Cricket Stadium

Cost

Paris 2024: $8.9 billion (Rs 75,650 crore)

Tokyo 2020: $13 billion (Rs 1.1 lakh crore)

India: Rs 35,000-Rs 64,000 crore ($4.1-7.5 billion)

At the heart of all the development is the Rs 4,000 crore Sardar Vallabhbhai Patel (SVP) Sports Enclave. It will house more than 10 stadiums, including those for football, a multi-purpose indoor arena, an aquatics centre and a tennis court. Fourteen other sporting venues are being readied within a 20 km radius. Sports infrastructure is also being developed at the Karai Police Training Academy, GIFT City and the Sanskardham Sports Academy (SSA) in Manipur-Godhavi village.

A site has also been identified for the athletes' village in the Sughad-Bhat area between Ahmedabad and Gandhinagar. Spread over 500 acres, it will have 3,000 housing units that can potentially accommodate up to 10,000 athletes and staff. Another land parcel of a similar size has been identified near SSA. At least two international consultants have been helping the Gujarat Olympic Planning and Infrastructure Corporation Ltd (GOLYMPIC) to prepare a masterplan for the Olympic village, while a third consultant is overseeing the development of the SVP sports enclave. The 11.5 km Sabarmati riverfront development, which currently ends just ahead of the Motera stadium, will be extended to 26.7 km up to GIFT City, Gandhinagar. The government is also acquiring land in Motera, including huge portions of convicted godman Asaram Bapu's ashram. Ahmedabad-Gandhinagar will have to fulfil the IOC prerequisite for the host city to have at least 40,000 hotel rooms to house tourists and staff, in addition to the Olympic village. Currently, the two cities have only 4,000 rooms between them.

The SVP sports enclave is also within walking distance of the Sabarmati multimodal transport hub, which will have the Mumbai-Ahmedabad bullet train station (expected to start by 2028); a metro and rail station each; and the Bus Rapid Transport System (BRTS). Another international airport at Dholera, 103 km from Ahmedabad, is expected to start operations by 2028.

The Gujarat government allocated Rs 250 crore for sports development in its budget this year. The MoS for home, sports and youth affairs Harsh Sanghavi informed the assembly that 13 new district sports complexes and 19 taluka sports complexes are being constructed. The Ahmedabad Municipal Corporation is spending another Rs 250 crore to build seven large sports complexes in the city. "These complexes will promote active lifestyles among the city's residents, particularly youth," says M. Thennarasan, GOLYMPIC CEO and former commissioner, Ahmedabad Municipal Corporation.

THE WEATHER MAY PLAY SPOILSPORT AS **GUJARAT IS EITHER BATTLING SUMMER OR THE MONSOONS** IN JULY-AUGUST WHEN OLYMPICS ARE HELD

WORRYING HEADWINDS

The weather will be a key challenge in Gujarat's bid for the Summer Olympics. Held in the months of July-August, Gujarat is either reeling under an extended summer at the time, or weathering a heavy monsoon. As a result, some events may be relocated—the canoeing slalom may move to Bhopal, mountain cycling to the Shivalik Hills in Uttarakhand, and sailing and surfing to Goa.

Equally difficult may be generating public support for the event in Gujarat, known more for its entrepreneurial prowess than a sporting spirit. What does work in the state's favour is the BJP's influence and control in every aspect of the state administration. Prohibition may prove another dampener but the government is said to be testing the waters by relaxing it in GIFT City and perhaps the Surat diamond bourse soon. There are also dynamics within the IOC to contend with. India has only one member in the 110-seat Olympic body—Reliance Foundation chairperson Nita Ambani. Former shooter and Olympic Council of Asia president Randhir Singh is among the 39 honorary members. Then there is the competition—Turkey, Saudi Arabia, South Africa, Indonesia and Qatar. Like India, none of them have hosted the Olympics before. Saudi Arabia and Qatar have a strong chance, as no West Asian country has held an Olympic so far. Ditto for South Africa and other African nations.

Yet, where there is a will, there is a way. And there is plenty of political will behind India's bid. Popular support is likely to build up too. As Malhotra says, "When people see the Olympics happening, it will open their eyes to the opportunities, and they will galvanise behind it." Wanting something badly enough, after all, is perhaps the first step toward achieving any goal. ■